

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 11

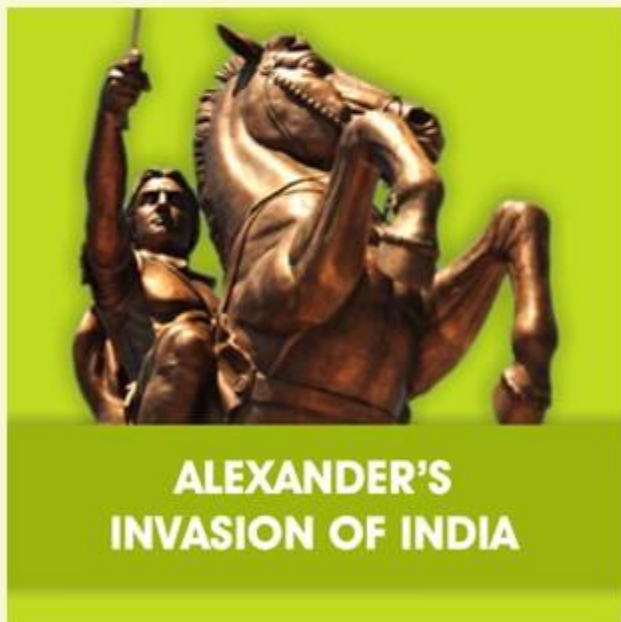
POST-MAURYAN ART-I

- SCULPTURES
- ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

Three prominent schools of sculpture developed in this period at three different regions of India – Centred at Gandhara, Mathura and Amaravati.

GANDHARA SCHOOL



1 After Alexander's invasion of India in 326 B.C., the Indo-Greek, Scythians and Kushan kings ruled over its north-western territories and under their patronage emerged a distinct style of sculpture, popularly known as the Greco-Roman, Buddhist or Gandhara art.

2 The Gandhara School of art developed in the western frontiers of Punjab, near modern day Peshwar and Afghanistan.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

Three prominent schools of sculpture developed in this period at three different regions of India – Centred at Gandhara, Mathura and Amaravati.

GANDHARA SCHOOL



Gandhara sculptures

3 The Greek invaders brought with them the traditions of the Greek and Roman Sculptors, which influenced the local traditions of the region.

4 It was a product of the combination of **Hellenistic, West Asiatic and native elements**. Thus Gandhara School also came to be known as Greco-Indian School of Art.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

GANDHARA SCHOOL

5 The Gandhara School flourished in two stages in the period from 50 B.C. to 500 A.D.

6 Greek and Roman techniques, modified according to Indian requirements, were employed in fashioning the Gandhara sculpture which truly represents Indian culture in a Western garb.

7 The subject-matter treated is predominantly Buddhist. Its area extended from Takshila in India to the Swat Valley in Pakistan and northwards to areas in Afghanistan.

8 The first century of the Christian era's revolutionary change, had far-reaching effects, not only on the art of India, but also on the artistic development of Buddhist countries of Asia.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

GANDHARA SCHOOL



Roman toga drapery

- 1 This school borrowed features from both the Greek and Roman art forms.
- 2 Many images of the Buddha from the Kushan period have Apollonian faces
- 3 Their hair is in the Graeco-Roman style and their draperies arranged in the style of a Roman toga.
- 4 This assimilation of artistic features was probably because many artisans from different countries trained in different schools came together under the Kushan rule.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

GANDHARA SCHOOL



Hair in Greco-Roman style

- 5 This school is influenced by Mahayana buddhism
- 6 Early phase used blue-grey sand stone, later on, apart from mud and lime plaster, stucco was used i.e. a type of plaster used for covering and decorating walls.
- 7 It exhibits minimum ornamentation with focus on symmetry.
- 8 Buddha who was hitherto designated only by a symbol, was conceived in human form.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

GANDHARA SCHOOL



9 His person was given some of the 32 auspicious bodily signs associated with the *Mahapurushalakshana*, such as the protuberance of the skull, the hair-knot, and elongated ears, eyelashes like a royal bull.

10 This change came about as a result of the new changes that had crept into the religious outlook of Buddhism due to the influence of the devotional School of Hindu Philosophy, requiring the worship of personal gods.

11 It must have exercised profound influence on the religious approach of the masses towards Buddhism. The image becomes henceforth the main element of sculpture and worship.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

GANDHARA SCHOOL



Yaksha model

- 12** Possibly, the emergence of the image of Buddha in Gandhara and in Mathura was a parallel development.
- 13** In each case, it was produced by the local artist craftsmen working in the local tradition. At Mathura it clearly emerges from the Yaksha tradition.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

GANDHARA SCHOOL

14

The Gandhara image might seem to resemble Apollo in some extraneous forms and does look characteristically Greco-Roman in drapery, but even there most of the images represent Buddha as seated in the typically Indian Yogic posture, a feature completely unknown to the Hellenistic tradition of art.



**Buddha seated in
yogic posture**



**Depiction of
Apollonian face**

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

FAMOUS EXAMPLES OF GANDHARA ART

1 GREAT DEPARTURE



1 The relief panel showing **Buddha's Great Departure** is a fine example of **Gandhara art** of the 2nd century A.D. Forsaking his wife, child and future kingdom in the quest of eternal bliss,

2 Prince Siddhartha is shown riding away on his favourite horse, Kanthaka, whose hoofs are lifted by two Yakshas to prevent the sound being heard by his family.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

FAMOUS EXAMPLES OF GANDHARA ART

1 GREAT DEPARTURE



3 His groom Chhandala, holds the royal umbrella over his head.

4 Mara, the Evil god, first sends his beautiful daughters to tempt him and then by attacking the Buddha with his army of demons here shown as ganas brandishing weapons and riding an elephant.

5 This is done so as to urge the Prince to abandon his pious intention. This incident, which was a turning point in the life of Gautama, is effectively portrayed.

Many versions/ depictions of the Great Departure



POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

FAMOUS EXAMPLES OF GANDHARA ART

2 STANDING BODHISATTAVA, GANDHARA



1 Another typical example of Gandhara art of 3rd century A.D. is the figure of a standing Bodhisattava.

2 His right hand is shown in the gesture of protection.

3 He is wearing a rich turban, a string of amulets across his body and strapped sandals on his feet.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

FAMOUS EXAMPLES OF GANDHARA ART

2

STANDING BODHISATTAVA, GANDHARA



4

The pedestal contains a pair of Corinthian pillars.

5

The athletic figure wearing a moustache, the heavy drapery folds of the garments and the strapped sandal all reveal the Greco-Roman influence.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

FAMOUS EXAMPLES OF GANDHARA ART

3

BUDDHA HEAD, TAXILA



1 The Buddha head from Taxila in the Gandhara region, now in Pakistan, dates back to the second century CE and belongs to the Kushana Period. The image shows hybridised pictorial conventions that developed during the Gandhara period.

2 It has Greco-Roman elements in the treatment of sculpture.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

FAMOUS EXAMPLES OF GANDHARA ART

3

BUDDHA HEAD, TAXILA



3

The Buddha head has typical Hellenistic elements that have grown over a period of time.

4

The curly hair of the Buddha is thick having a covered layer of sharp and linear strokes over the head.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

FAMOUS EXAMPLES OF GANDHARA ART

3

BUDDHA HEAD, TAXILA



5 The **forehead plane is large** having protruding eyeballs, the eyes are half-closed and the face and cheeks are not round like the images found in other parts of India.

6 There is a certain amount of heaviness in the figures of the Gandhara region.

7 The **ears are elongated** especially the earlobes.

8 The treatment of the form bears linearity and the outlines are sharp.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

FAMOUS EXAMPLES OF GANDHARA ART

3

BUDDHA HEAD, TAXILA



9 The surface is smooth. The image is very expressive.

10 The **interplay of light and dark** is given considerable attention by using the curving and protruding planes of the eye-socket and the planes of the nose.

11 The **expression of calmness** is the centre point of attraction. Modelling of the face **enhances the naturalism of three-dimensionality**.

POST-MAURYAN SCHOOLS OF ART

FAMOUS EXAMPLES OF GANDHARA ART

3

BUDDHA HEAD, TAXILA

- 12** Assimilating various traits of Acamenian, Parthian and Bactrian traditions into the local tradition is a hallmark of the Gandhara style.
- 13** The Gandhara images have physiognomic features of the Greco-Roman tradition but they display a very distinct way of treating **physiognomic details that are not completely Greco-Roman**.
- 14** The source of development of Buddha images as well as others has its **genesis in its peculiar geopolitical conditions**.
- 15** It may also be observed that the north-western part of India, which is now **Pakistan, always had continuous habitation from proto-historic times**.
- 16** It continued in the historical period as well. A large number of images have been found in the Gandhara region. They **consist of narratives of the life of the Buddha, narrations from the Jataka stories, and Buddha and Boddhisattva images**.

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